

KING OF PRUSSIA (1712–86)

FREDERICK II

Frederick II, king of Prussia from 1740, is perhaps the archetypal 18th-century enlightened despot (see p.271). He believed in absolute power, but generally used it for the good of his subjects, establishing religious toleration, abolishing torture as an instrument of state power, and freeing the slaves on his own estates. An able and cultured man—he corresponded with the French philosopher Voltaire, and wrote music for the flute, which he played well—he was also a ruthless figure on the European stage and a brilliant military commander, raising Prussia to the first rank of European powers.



“In the end God will have pity on us and **crush this monster.**”

AUSTRIAN EMPRESS MARIA THERESA, SPEAKING OF FREDERICK II, 1757

Russians at Zorndorf, Prussia, in August 1758. In India, British general Robert Clive (see pp.352–53) defeated the Nawab of Bengal at Plassey in June 1757, while the British navy routed the French off the Indian coast in 1758–59.

The turning point of the war came in 1759, the British “year of victories.” The first years of the war in America had seen French success, but James Wolfe turned the tide for the British, by capturing Louisbourg in 1758, and

then by defeating general Montcalm in Quebec, the capital of French North America, in 1759. In Europe, an Anglo-German army defeated the French in Hanover, while the French navy was crushed off the coast of Brittany.

The seizure of French Montreal in 1760, and Pondicherry, in India, in 1761 effectively marked the end of the war, despite the entry of Spain on the French side in 1761. With the succession in 1762 of the pro-Prussian Peter III in Russia, all nations were ready for peace. The 1763 Treaty of Paris saw Britain take French North America, and all French lands east of the Mississippi, as well as parts of the Caribbean, and every French fort in India. Spain gave Florida to Britain, but received French lands west of the Mississippi in return. With the French excluded from North America and India, Britain now controlled a massive colonial and trading empire.

The Battle of Zorndorf

Frederick II of Prussia followed up his decisive defeats of the French and Austrians in 1757 with an equally impressive victory over the Russians at Zorndorf in western Poland on August 25, 1758.

The end of the war saw Britain victorious, but also vulnerable.

AMERICAN REVOLUTION

French **revenge** on Britain was swift. France helped America in its war of independence against Britain after 1777 **298–99** >>

THE BIRTH OF THE BRITISH RAJ

The end of French power in India left Britain without a rival in its **conquest of the entire subcontinent**. By the 1830s, Britain had gained Bengal and Bihar in the east, and ruled over much of the south and center **352–53** >>



BRITISH RULE IN INDIA

POLAND

A byproduct of the war was the **end of Poland** as an independent nation. Squashed between Prussia, Austria, and Russia, Poland was divided by the three powers after 1772. In 1795, it was absorbed piecemeal by Russia, Prussia, and Austria, and did not reappear until 1918.

